Weapons

By Mary Krell-Oishi

(SHERYL is getting ready for MIKE's party and during her conversation does her hair and makeup.)

SHERYL: I call these my weapons. This blush is one of those kinds that has two tones of peachy rose for accenting the cheekbones. I've got the kind of coloring that if I go with peachy I look jaundiced, and if I go with rose I look like some kind of cheap tart, so if I mix the two I get just the right amount of fresh and natural non-make-uppy look. Natural fiber blush brush, too. No polyester here! Eye liner in two shades, brown and dark brown. You don't want black because it's way too harsh. But if you go with light brown you might as well not wear any at all, so what's the point? And you have to use the pencil because the liquid stuff smears and wiggles. But don't put it on too thick, because if you do it defeats the purpose of enlarging the eye. Start at the middle of the eye and go outward. It's a matter of practice, that's all. And don't forget about mascara, thick lash, of course. But you have to be careful with the mascara because if you get the cheap stuff it gets all clumpy and makes you look like Tammy Faye, may God forbid. I spend a lot of money on mascara because my eyes are my best feature and you can't cheat on the lashes. The rest of this stuff I get at the dollar counter at the Pic and Save. To be honest, it's all pretty much the same. Except the mascara. It's important to remember the difference. I get mine at Nordstrom's. I know it's extravagant, but think about it. So I spend an

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extra two or three dollars and I have the satisfaction of knowing that my eyes will look great. It's sort of like a little insurance policy. I hope you're paying attention.

INTRODUCTION

Tens of billions of dollars are spent each year by women worldwide on makeup and other cosmetic products. Why? Women have discovered that beauty is power. When a woman improves her appearance, an amazing thing happens. People begin to pay attention to her, listen to her, seek her company, ask her opinion. She becomes more confident. As her confidence grows, so does the respect she receives – at work, at home, everywhere. Lipstick, blush and mascara become tools for some and for some . . . Weapons by Mary Krell-Oishi

SHERYL: The lips are important, too. Very important, especially on a night like tonight. You want to have color, but you don't want it to make a mess if you get together with someone. I usually go with a strawberry gloss. You don't want to get the kind in a pot that you put on with your fingers because then you get all icky and where do you wipe your hands and it's always a mess. Nope. You get this stuff at the Pic and Save, right at the counter, and you can't go wrong. It comes in this handy little tube that fits perfectly in your pocket. Not only that, it's soft and flexible, so if you are wearing something that doesn't have pockets, you can stick it in your bra, which is an asset, because then it stays warm and goes on easier. And always wear a bra. Trust me, you'll regret it later if you don't. Look at all those women from the sixties and seventies who didn't. Sag city. Pitiful.

Mike's party tonight is supposed to be a very big deal, so I want to look

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good. Everyone will be there. We've all been waiting a long time for a party like this, our last party before we all graduate. His parents are gone, but it won't be rowdy because we're not the kind of kids to be stupid. We have respect for Mike's home and his parents' faith in him. So, it won't be like Chuck's party was where the whole football team came and drank and proceeded to act like fools and tear up the house.

That was awful, really awful. Of course, look at Chuck. He's like a walking advertisement for teenage evil. He was right in the middle of all that, encouraging it. And when his parents got home and saw that disaster, they didn't do anything about it. Just called in some professional house cleaners, had the carpets replaced and repaired the guest toilet in the downstairs bathroom. I don't know what happens to teenage guys when they get too much beer in them. It must be some sort of testosterone thing that I just don't understand. But at Mike's it will be a lot better. Yeah, everyone is invited. Well, I mean, everyone knows about this party, but that doesn't mean it will be some big blowout. Just a lot of nice people mingling and stuff. There will be a few people there that I really want to see, and some that I really want to see me. That's why I need my weapons. And that's why I'm taking my time putting this stuff on. I want to look beautiful, but not made up, see? Which reminds me, never ever wear face makeup, like powder or pancake or any of that. You only wear face makeup when you are on stage or you're old and have a lot of wrinkles to hide, like when you're thirty.

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You want to look natural, kissable. The last thing a guy wants to see is your face melting off onto his shirt. A real turn off, trust me. Anyway, I figure this is going to be about the last high school party I go to. I've been going to high school parties since I was in junior high. That's five years of high school parties. (It's kind of weird to think that some of the guys I got together with when I was a freshman are now graduating from college. Hmmm.) Anyway, I want to look really good for this last party. So I hope you don't mind if I finish getting ready while I talk. I have all this worked out to a science. See, if I just follow a simple plan of attack I can be fully made up and looking pretty damn good in just about eleven minutes. Not bad! I know some girls take all day to get ready. Pathetic. There's so much more to do in life than primp, you know? But some people, I guess, just find it necessary to spend all day in front of a mirror doing something that shouldn't take more than a couple minutes.

Do you like this outfit? I do, even though it's jeans. I know some girls don't like to wear jeans. Heather won't even wear pants. "Girls wear dresses, boys wear pants," that's what she always says. But I'm perfectly comfortable in a good pair of nice-fittingjeans. And jeans are a good thing to wear, a good basic. You can look like a slob in jeans, but take those very same jeans, put on a nice button-down shirt and a blazer, and if you're feeling really funky, a thin tie and tuck those jeans into some black boots and you look very good. Want to look classy?

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Same outfit, add a pair of earrings and put your hair up and, voila', you are right off the cover of YM magazine. Never, though, wear heels with jeans. Hello, tramp! if you do. Trust me on this one.

A lot of people are going to be at this party tonight. It should be pretty fun. But since this is my last appearance at a high school party, I want to make an impression that will last. God, I hate to think I'd turn into one of those losers that keep going to high school parties after they graduate. I'm counting on the fact that Nick Carloti will be there. In fact, I bet you solid money that Nick will be there. He graduated, what, four years ago? I remember, and God this is embarrassing to admit, but I remember being so impressed with myself for macking with him when he was a senior and I was a freshman. I thought he was the beginning and end of the world. Now, it's just humiliating to think about it. I mean, look at him. He's been out of school for four years and he's doing exactly the same thing he did when he was in high school. A lot of talk about all the things he's going to do, but never any action to get him there. It's sad, really.

Nick, however, is one of the reasons I want to look especially good tonight. Boy, did he use me four years ago. Took advantage of my innocent nature. I'm not saying we did anything more than mac, because we didn't. I was young and stupid, but not a fool. What he did was play with my feelings, lead me into thinking that there was going to be a real relationship there. God, I was dumb. I mean, really, what would a popular

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senior like Nick see in a little freshman like me? Dh, he'd tell me how he loved me and there was no one else. And, yeah, I knew in my brain he was lying, but in my heart I wanted to believe it. First love, you know? Even some of the senior girls took me aside and told me what a cheating worm he was and what he was doing. But would I listen? No siree, not me. I told them that that's how he used to be, but I would change him. Dumb, huh? But I learned a really good lesson, you know. I learned that people are who they are and they are not going to change. You either love someone for who they are or move on. I can thank Nick for that. He was a good learning experience. He was fun, but he was ajerk and didn't really care about anyone but himself. I learned that that's not the kind of person I want in my life. A good lesson to learn early, rather than waiting until you're in your twenties and marrying an idiot hoping he'll turn into a decent person. 'Cause they won't. But the nasty little vindictive side of me wants Nick to see that the little girl whose mind he messed with is now a grown woman.

Here's my plan. I am going to walk into that party looking so fine that all heads will turn. See, this is the perfect outfit to wear, too. Casual enough to look like I just threw something together, but smart enough to look stylish and stunning. And I'll tell you, jogging five miles every day does wonders for the fit of your jeans! So, I will sashay right up to Nick, give him a big hug and ask how he's doing. He, of course, will tell me about how things are just about coming together for him. How he's going to start going on auditions for agents or he's thinking about getting back

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into singing. You know, the same old same old he's always talking about. Of course, he won't ask me about what I'm doing, but I'll work the conversation around to me eventually. OK, look at me. Hair, makeup, outfit. I look great, right? My weapons are all in place. I'm looking pretty devastating if I do say so myself. But! Here's the atomic bomb that I am going to drop on him. You ready?! I just found out today that I got accepted to Yale! Ha! Yale! And I got a couple of scholarships that will cover most of the costs. And I did it all with my own talents, determination and brains. I'm going to Yale!

My point here is this: Nick and I had the same four years. What has he done? Not much. Stagnated, works as a waiter in the same place he did four years ago. Talked a good game, but never got off the bench to play it. But in those same four years I worked hard and it paid off. It paid off big. That's the main weapon I have. Me! So, yeah, I do the makeup, hair and clothes thing. But I have a future that includes more than just looking good. Everything I do is up to me. And that, my young friend, is the best weapon of all.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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